dominating feature during the election period; and in view of the major stakes at this watershed election for old and new power brokers. Further research into why the ballot remained peaceful should be encouraged; for now, it appears that the political will for peaceful elections was strong enough, and the costs of escalating political violence deemed too high to bear. International support, incentives, and diplomatic pressure for credible and peaceful elections also contributed to a peaceful transfer of power.

The lessons learned during this electoral process should be transferred from the old to the new UEC leadership. A new cycle of capacity building in the UEC should have a dedicated focus on conflict sensitivity and reaching conflict-affected communities, such as the internally displaced. Conflict-affected communities and their representatives (whether members of political parties or EAGs) should become targeted beneficiaries of civic and voter education in the future, in particular in ceasefire areas and areas where elections were cancelled. Whatever parliamentary or extra-parliamentary discussion and decision-making forums will develop, they should include and address outstanding electoral reforms. The existing majoritarian electoral system deserves a review in a participatory manner, although it is unlikely the NLD would embrace major change to the current system, which helped it to convert the popular vote to a disproportionately high number of seats (see Lemargie et al 2014). If the existing system remains, however, to enable a more equal suffrage, as a minimum the new administration would be advised to review the constituency boundaries to avoid another election with severe malapportionment. As the existing boundaries derive from the 2008 Constitution and new delimitation would require constitutional change, this topic has to be addressed in a transparent and consultative manner.

The UEC proved open to enhancing the electoral process towards international standards. Some of these measures were developed following international advice, such as new integrity measures for the polls, increased interaction with political parties and CSOs, and intensified voter education. Other elements of the process came from within the institution. New measures to mitigate the risks of electoral violence included the introduction of a political party Code of Conduct, signed by almost all registered parties; the introduction of UEC-led mediation committees, which helped diffuse tensions between parties in some cases; the introduction of police-led electoral security management committees, largely consisting of administrators and security forces, to operationalize electoral security